Chapter 9

Acts of Conscience:
Innovative and Reformative Policing

KIRAN HAS ALWAYS VIEWED THE PRIMARY ROLE OF THE POLICE AS BEING one of prevention of crime, crime correction, while at the same time, focusing on crime detection and effective prosecution. There are many instances that convince one of her conviction. As mentioned in Chapter 8, in 1980, for example, when she got rid of the menace of bootlegging.

That year, when she was the deputy commissioner of police (West District), Delhi, the crime scene had revealed that illicit brewing and bootlegging were prominent. In August 1986, she was appointed DCP, North District. For her now it was the sale and consumption of 'smack' (a street name for heroin) that was the focus of criminal activities. One reason for the drop in bootlegging could, of course, have been the increase in official liquor vending as the Delhi Administration became a bit more liberal in its prohibition policy.

As she became more and more determined to check drug-related criminality, she got socially involved with the problem too. It was apparent to her that drugs and crime went together and she became intent on pursuing the subject of cause and effect even academically. She delved into books on the subject and found that although some work had been done on this topic in the West, there was very little literature available on the Indian scenario. Cursory findings revealed that a majority of drug abuse cases led to crime in the form of domestic violence, and not just verbal abuse, but to a great extent mental torture as well as physical violence.

What was surprising was that such violence was rarely directed towards the fathers or the brothers of the male addicts but almost always towards the mothers and the wives. They were 'soft targets' from whom money, jewellery and even clothes could be extracted to sustain the habit.

Section 47 of the Delhi Police Act is not often put to use. And yet, it empowers the DCP with scope for punitive powers, permitting him or her to use persuasive correctional methods and, if he or she is so inclined, to undertake a lot of correctional reforms. In keeping with her inclinations Kiran made effective use of these powers.

Armed with such powers she could initiate externment proceedings against anyone who had breached the law three times and whose being at large was a threat to general peace and security of the area. She could ask the person concerned to show cause why he or she should not be asked to leave the city limits. This would perforce compel the person to live in unfamiliar environments, away from his or her area of influence. He or she, then, would have stood effectively uprooted. Yet, such an individual could be permitted to stay in the city as long as he or she was not found to be violating the law. This threat certainly did dissuade many drug pushers. The brilliance of this scheme was that without a single person being uprooted, *all* of them came under social control and the residents heaved sighs of relief.